HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"The app has been heaven-sent"

After the passing of their father two years ago, Chikkaballapur resident Ramesh P. and his four siblings have been working through the process of partitioning their family's agricultural property. For this, they turned to Dishaank, a smartphone app developed by the Karnataka revenue department. The app provides comprehensive details about any piece of land, including a cadastral map. Using Dishaank, they could draw polygons on the map, measure various permutations, and evaluate options—all from their phone—enabling them to make informed decisions. "We are measuring at home itself and can see who will get how much," says Ramesh. An additional consideration was a 220 kV electricity line earmarked to pass through their land, requiring an equitable apportionment. "We could calculate that here too," Ramesh notes. The app, he adds, has been heaven-sent. ■



RAMESH P., 60
Chikkaballapur, Karnataka

THE EASE OF LIVING

By 2002, Karnataka's revenue department had become the first in India to digitise the Record of Rights, Tenancy and Crops (RTC), under the pioneering Bhoomi project. The RTC is a master document containing details about a property—ownership, liens, soil type and crop information—essential for transactions like sales, mortgages or availing agricultural schemes. With digitisation, the RTC became accessible online, revolutionising land record management.

Building on this foundation, Karnataka developed a suite of web applications to enhance citizen services. By integrating Bhoomi with property registration and survey databases, the state enabled online access for stakeholders, including banks. Landowners no longer need to visit government offices; they can initiate service requests online and download RTC documents.

Another milestone was reached in 2023 with the automation of the RTC mutation processes. Karnataka processes 2 million RTC mutations annually, 67 per cent of which don't require a mandatory notice period. Earlier, farmers needed to make multiple visits to update the RTC. Now, this process is automatic, reducing the average disposal time to just 0.73 days, far below the five-day limit mandated by the Karnataka Guarantee of Services to Citizens Act, 2011. "This is a revolutionary step that we have taken, and it is helping farmers to a great extent," says revenue commissioner Pommala Sunil Kumar.

Landowners no longer need to visit government offices; they can initiate service requests online and download documents

In February 2024, the state launched Bhu Suraksha, modernising record rooms with part funding by the DILRMP. Within a year, 80 million pages of legacy records were scanned and digitised in eight sub-districts, with efforts ongoing across the state. "The entire revenue department is now coming under e-office," Kumar notes. Officials at all levels, from village administrative officers to higher authorities, now rely on a bevy of apps developed by the Bengaluru-based Bhoomi Monitoring Cell.

Another transformative step is the Aadhaar-RTC linking of 87 per cent of Karnataka's 41 million plots through eKYC, enabling farmers to receive automatic SMS updates on land transactions. The ongoing digitisation drive has also uncovered discrepancies, such as illegal occupation of government land or fraudulent land grant claims. Notably, 97 per cent of the 1.4 million government-owned land parcels have now been digitally mapped. "Digitisation is a means to an end, and the end-objective is to deliver better governance," says revenue minister Krishna Byregowda. "We are working to clean up the legacy mess and put Karnataka on the path to title security." ■